

TOPIC 5 How a Lie Travels

Why false stories spread faster than the corrections that follow them.

THE POINT OF THE BLOCK

False stories spread because they are **new** and because they produce **strong emotions**. People, not bots, do most of the spreading. A real check takes about two minutes and **names what you looked at**.

SAY IT RIGHT

Apr 2013	The AP Twitter account is hacked: explosions at the White House, the president injured. Market drops sharply within seconds , recovers within minutes.
Apr 2018	Jordan Peele and BuzzFeed release a video of Obama he had nothing to do with, made to show people it was possible.
2018	Vosoughi, Roy and Aral (MIT), in <i>Science</i> : about 126,000 rumor cascades over 11 years . False spread farther and faster. They removed all bot activity and the finding held . Explanation: novelty and emotion.
2016	Veles, North Macedonia : BuzzFeed News traced US political hoax sites to one town. In the final three months, top false election stories drew more Facebook engagement than the top real ones.
Dec 2016	Pizzagate : nothing to it. A man drove from another state and fired a rifle inside the restaurant. Nobody hurt, which was luck.
Feb 2018	A US grand jury indicts 13 Russian nationals and the Internet Research Agency. The described aim was largely widening divisions , not backing a candidate.
2018	Cambridge Analytica : profile data on tens of millions via a quiz app, used for political targeting. \$5B FTC penalty , 2019.
2011–15	Pariser names the filter bubble (2011). Bakshy, Messing and Adamic , <i>Science</i> (2015): clicks mattered more than ranking, and those authors worked for Facebook . Read carefully, do not throw out.

DEFINE OUT LOUD

Misinformation — false, spread by somebody who thinks it is true.

Disinformation — false, spread by somebody who knows it is false.

Lateral reading — leave the page and find out who published it.

Clickbait · deepfake · bot · echo chamber · microtargeting — each in the sentence it first appears.

THE CHECK, IN ORDER OF RETURN

- Who published this?
- When? Old stories recirculate as new ones constantly.
- Does anybody else report it? If only one outlet has it, why?
- What is the earliest version? The one you saw is several hands down the chain.
- For a photograph, a reverse image search.

For a claim you have already seen five times, **read Snopes or FactCheck.org**. Somebody has done the work; reading it is faster than repeating it.

THE CLASS, IN ORDER

- Open cold on the speed gap. Two words, one difference: **the sender**.
- Four tactics: clickbait, deepfake, bots, emotion. Bots make a claim look **popular**; they are not there to persuade anyone.
- Put it next to Topic 3: the system rewards reaction, so **nobody has to decide to promote a lie**.
- The MIT study. Design first, finding second, bots-removed third. Let them draw the conclusion.
- Demonstrate lateral reading live** on one real claim. Narrate the tabs.
- Elections, fast pass: pause only on procedure and the regulation gap. Then the echo chamber, held loosely.

DO NOT

- Do not moralize about screens**. The second it sounds like an adult warning, the room files it away and stops reading.
- Do not teach blanket doubt**. Doubting everything equally is paralysis, and it helps anyone running a campaign. The goal is **calibration**.
- Do not let "it was bots" stand**. It is comfortable: it puts the problem outside the room.
- Do not say social media decided an election**. The mechanisms are documented. The size is not.

THEY WRITE

- One post that gave you a strong emotional reaction. **Name the emotion**, then how it made people more likely to share it.
- Check one claim by lateral reading. **Write what you did**: who published it, when, and whether another source reports it.
- One item from Part Five, **in three steps**: how could it change an election result?

END ON
The main fix is not technical. It is the two seconds before you repost.

TOPIC 6 Who Gets to Decide?

On the first day I said I would ask you a hard question at the end. This is it.

THE QUESTION, WORD FOR WORD

Who should get to decide what a platform is allowed to do to your attention: **you, the company, or the government**?

Not graded on which they choose. Graded on how well they state the strongest version of one they **did not** choose.

SAY THIS BEFORE THE ARGUMENT STARTS

Every one of these positions is held by serious people who have thought about it longer than we have.

The trap: if a position seems obviously wrong, they are arguing against a weak version of it, and beating that teaches nothing.

Tradeoff — what you give up in order to get something else. **An answer with no tradeoff in it is not finished**.

THE THREE, CASE AND TRADEOFF

YOU	
Case	It is your attention and your phone, and the controls already exist.
Tradeoff	A large, well-funded team on one side, your willpower on the other.
COMPANY	
Case	They built it. Self-regulation is real: bad press does move them.
Tradeoff	Fixing the problem means giving up the thing that makes them money.
GOVERNMENT	
Case	Regulation is ordinary: seatbelts, no cigarette ads on TV, no full-time child labor.
Tradeoff	The same power that protects people can be used to control them.

Unintended consequence: rules written for large platforms hurt small ones the most, because they cannot afford the lawyers new rules require. Belongs in the argument, does not settle it.

PRECEDENT: IT HAS HAPPENED FOUR TIMES

1954	Comic books. Senate hearing, industry code. Research largely discredited later .
1970s	Television violence. Hearings across the decade.
1985	Music lyrics. Senate hearings, the parental advisory sticker.
1993	Video games. Hearings, the rating on every box. Research still contested .
4 of 4	Ended with the industry regulating itself under threat of government action , rather than in a law.

Three differences any precedent argument must survive: it is **personalized**, it is **always with you**, and it **responds to what you do**. A comic book did not know who was holding it.

SECTION 230, THE ONE FACT THAT CHANGES THE FEEL

In plain terms: if a user posts something illegal, the user can be held responsible. The platform usually cannot.

1996	That protection becomes law, in Section 230 of the Communications Decency Act.
1997	The rest of that law is struck down by the Supreme Court. 230 survives .
Since	Lawmakers from both parties have tried to change or remove it, for different reasons. It is still the law.

THE CLASS, IN ORDER

- Read the question. **Stop talking**. Nobody answers yet.
- Straw poll by hands, no discussion**. Write the split on the board and leave it.
- Ground rule, then the standard. Hold them to the tradeoff all block.
- Each position: strongest case first, from somebody who **disagrees**. Then the tradeoff, and **do not resolve it**.
- Case and tradeoff across all three. Cannot name their own tradeoff, not ready to write.
- The four precedents. Ask what the four have in common **before** you say it.
- Break the precedent on purpose with the three differences.
- Section 230, then back to the board: **who moved, and why?**

DO NOT

- Do not answer the tradeoff for them**. It is the honest shape of the argument, not a rhetorical setup.
- Do not let the weak version win**. If the room agrees too fast, they beat a strawman.
- Do not signal your own position**. They will write toward it.
- Do not let precedent settle it**. Using one well names what is the same *and* what is different.

THEY WRITE

- The position they do **not** agree with, stated as strongly as they can.
- One earlier argument: what happened, then **one way social media is different**.
- What evidence would change your mind? Specific enough to go looking for.

END ON
State the other side well enough that somebody who holds it would say you got it right.

BOTH BLOCKS

REGISTER

Short sentences, one idea each, concrete before abstract. Flat and curious, never ominous.

TWO TIERS, ALWAYS

Start Here and Push Further are **both real answers**. Say it out loud. Confidence is **not graded**: a Shaky tells you more than a dishonest Could teach it.

GETTING THE WORK IN

Answers save in that browser on that device only. **Gather All My Work**, Copy, paste into Canvas. Nothing reaches you until they paste.